When we use `redirect_to` to transfer control to another action, the browser generates a separate request to invoke that action. That request will be handled by our application in a fresh instance of a controller object—instance variables that were set in the original action aren't available to the code handling the redirected action. But sometimes we need to communicate between these two instances. We can do this using a facility called the *flash*.

The flash is a temporary scratchpad for values. It's organized like a hash and stored in the session data, so you can store values associated with keys and later retrieve them. It has one special property. By default, values stored into the flash during the processing of a request will be available during the processing of the immediately following request. Once that second request has been processed, those values are removed from the flash.

Probably the most common use of the flash is to pass error and informational strings from one action to the next. The intent here is that the first action notices some condition, creates a message describing that condition, and redirects to a separate action. By storing the message in the flash, the second action is able to access the message text and use it in a view. An example of such usage can be found in Iteration E1.

It's sometimes convenient to use the flash as a way of passing messages into a template in the current action. For example, our `display` method might want to output a cheery banner if there isn't another, more pressing note. It doesn't need that message to be passed to the next action—it's for use in the current request only. To do this, it could use `flash.now`, which updates the flash but doesn't add to the session data.

While `flash.now` creates a transient flash entry, `flash.keep` does the opposite, making entries that are currently in the flash stick around for another request cycle. If you pass no parameters to `flash.keep`, then all the flash contents are preserved.